

The safety tools nobody used.

1.8%

of teenagers used the feature Instagram offered voluntarily. And the law that changed everything never issued a fine.

THE FINDING

Take a Break reached 1.8 percent of teens.

Optional from December 2021, default only from September 2024. Confirmed under oath the day before Meta settled. The famous 90 percent figure covered only the teens who ever switched it on.

THE COUNTER CASE

The most effective intervention issued no fine.

The UK's design code flipped defaults on every major platform worldwide: TikTok private by default for 13 to 15s, YouTube autoplay off for under 18s, Instagram under 16s private. Zero fines under the Code itself.

THE TEST

47 teen safety tools tested. 30 failed.

Independent testing found 64 percent of Instagram's teen safety tools ineffective or discontinued.

Fairplay, the Molly Rose Foundation and Cybersecurity for Democracy, 2025.

THE REFRAME

Evasion defeats gates. It does not defeat design.

A child can lie past an age gate. Nobody can VPN past autoplay being off, hidden like counts, or a filter that does not exist.

TO BE FAIR

Settled means never proven.

No court in the states' case ruled on what caused what, because Meta settled. The one adjudicated fund, New Mexico's \$567 million, is under appeal.

WHERE SIX PARTS LAND

**Fines feed treasuries.
Design reaches children.
Families hold the third layer.**

A plan the child helps write has nothing to switch off and
nothing to climb over.

FOLLOW THE MONEY, PART 6 OF 6

Design beats punishment, and families beat both.

The whole series is on my profile. The free starter pack is in the first comment. If this series landed, repost this one.

The Guided Digital Childhood, guidedchildhood.com